March
2026

ASMInk

Newsletter of the Archeological Society of Maryland, Inc.

Two Recent Archaeological Context Studies by SHA

Lisa Kraus, Archeologist, SHA

In 2024, the Maryland Department of Transportation State Highway Administration (SHA)'s Historic Preservation Division partnered with consultants to develop two historical and archaeological context studies. The *Native American Trails to Historic Roads: Historic Context and Methodology* focused on understanding the cultural and historical landscape of Maryland's transportation system and its roots in complex Native American trade and travel networks. The *African American Historic and Archaeological Context Needs Assessment* highlights the importance of incorporating African American history into archaeological studies, particularly in transportation projects, and provides direction for the development of comprehensive and meaningful archaeological contexts pertaining to Maryland's diverse Black past.

The *Native American Trails to Historic Roads: Historic Context and Methodology* was developed in partnership with indigenous Marylanders and explores the precontact trail system in Maryland, with a focus on trails that became part of the state roadway system, and relates the major trails to key resources such as well-known large habitation sites or historically documented villages. In addition to exploring the history of the identified trails, the study includes least cost path analyses to assess whether the roads identified during the historical background review would have served as ideal pathways on foot, and depictions of the identified trails on historic maps. The context may contribute towards the identification, interpretation, and evaluation of Native American sites in the future, and is accompanied by a Geographic Information System (GIS) record of the paths.

The *African American Historic and Archaeological Context Needs Assessment* provides an archaeological framework for recording and researching African American sites, particularly for transportation and other Section 106 compliance projects. The study includes a review of known archeological sites and architectural resources; a proposed list of Periods of Significance and a Site Typology for African American archeological sites; and a summary of recommendations for the development of an African American Archaeological Context for Maryland.

Board Notes:

Ethan Bean
ASM Membership Secretary

For this board note I want to share a few of my favorite mobile applications that I use in the field and for various recreational purposes: (1) SoilWeb, (2) Rockd, and (3) Scaniverse. It's important to note that I use these on my iOS device and can't speak to their use or availability on the Android platform.

SoilWeb - As archaeologists, we're constantly working in, and interpreting, soils. Developed by the University of California, Davis, SoilWeb provides a general snapshot of the soils in any geographic area by linking back to information provided by the U.S. Natural Resources Conservation Service. The app includes information on soil horizons, texture, land classification, parent material, and drainage, among others. It's essentially like having the web soil survey on the go!

Rockd - This app is more geologically focused, showing physiographic provinces, stratigraphic groups and formations, and local lithologies based on your geographic location. While not specific to archaeology, the Rockd app can provide useful information about the landscape, site formation processes, and soil parent material (especially in upland areas where residual soils dominate).

Scaniverse - Scaniverse is a scanning app that utilizes photogrammetry and LiDAR (in applicable devices) to capture 3D images of objects and features. In my work, I've used this to digitally record both historic brick features and headstones. Captures can then be uploaded and saved to various online locations, such as SketchFab.

With field season on the horizon (soil pun), I hope any of these are useful to you in reading and recording the landscape!

Upcoming Events:

- **2026 Middle Atlantic Archeology Conference**, Gettysburg, PA
  March 11 - 15, 2026
  MAAC Conference Information
- **Discovering Archeology Day 2026**
  Jefferson Patterson Park
  Saturday, April 12th, 2026
  11 a.m. – 4 p.m.
- **Annual Spring Symposium**
  People's Resource Center
  100 Community Pl
  Crownsville, MD 21032
  Saturday, April 18th, 2026
- **2026 Tyler Bastian Field Session**
  May 22 - June 1, 2026
  Teague's Point Site
  Calvert County, MD
  Registration is Open
- **Paleoamerican Odyssey**
  Santa Fe, New Mexico
  October 14-17, 2026
  Center For the Study of the First Americans

Hettie Ballweber:

Career and Oral History Summary

Hettie Ballweber, Stephen Israel and Wayne Clark

Hettie was born in December 1944 in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. Her father and mother worked for the Pennsylvania Railroad. She grew up in Monongahela and graduated from Monongahela High School in 1963. During her childhood, she was exposed to her family's love of reading and developed an ardent desire to travel. She loved reading about archaeology and dreamed of becoming an archaeologist.

She married at age 18 and her dream to travel was fulfilled when she and her Navy husband were transferred around the United States living in six states and Japan for 12 years. While living in Japan, she read "*The Source*" by James Michener and decided that she would become an archaeologist.

When her husband's enlistment was up, they moved back to Pennsylvania for eight years, raising their two sons. When her son graduated from high school, she felt the time had arrived to pursue her archaeological aspirations. She learned about the Society for Pennsylvania Archaeology (SPA) and joined the Westmoreland Archaeological Society (WAS) and volunteered with the Carnegie Museum of Natural History in excavating a number of sites across Southwestern Pennsylvania. While active in the WAS, she served as recording secretary, corresponding secretary, and vice president. She also completed the SPA/WAS Lay Archaeologist certification program, one of the first three people in the state to do so.

In 1979, Hettie enlisted in the US Navy reserves spending her active-duty time at the Patuxent River Naval Air Station flying with her squadron to Bermuda, Spain, and the Azores.

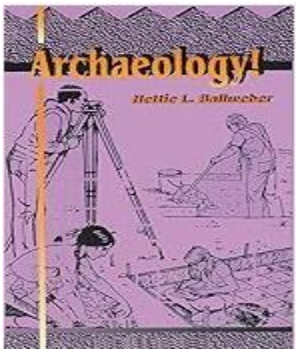
She ventured out on her own after her first marriage ended, enrolling in 1982 at California University of Pennsylvania to earn her degree. She began working for Dr. Ronald Michael, owner of NPW Consultants, Inc., conducting numerous projects in Pennsylvania and West Virginia.

Receiving her bachelor's degree in Anthropology in 1985, Hettie moved to Maryland where she met and married Bill Ballweber. While working for the Maryland Geological Survey, Division of Archaeology, State Archeologist, Tyler Bastian, encouraged her to publish a major paper about the excavations at the Friendsville site in Western Maryland and publish a paper about radiocarbon dating in Maryland. Tyler allowed her time away from work to attend her classes to obtain her Masters of Applied Anthropology degree at the UMD in 1987. Hettie published her first book, called "*The First People of Maryland*", in 1987.

She went back to work for Dr. Michael, conducting some of her largest CRM projects in Maryland, Ohio, New York, Virginia, Maryland and Pennsylvania, while also establishing her own CRM firm – ACS Consultants – where she conducted numerous projects in Maryland. During her time with NPW, she excavated the Burrall site, a Middle Woodland rhyolite processing site associated with the Highland rhyolite quarry in Frederick County.

In 1990-1991, she served as the president of the Council for Maryland Archaeology, during which time the *Abstracts in Archeology* was published and a Common Ground Conference was hosted. In 1993 and 1995, she won the Achievement in Archaeology award for excavations she conducted at Anne Arundel County's prehistoric Luce Creek Site and the historic Harwood Plantation site. One of her largest projects involved conducting excavations at the Schifferstadt site, an 18th century architectural museum owned by Frederick County Landmarks Foundation that yielded valuable information about the history and inhabitants at the site which became a National Historic Landmark in 2018.

In 1996 Hettie wrote her second book, "*Archaeology!*", aimed at informing children about archaeology. She became the editor of ASM Ink serving for six years. She was a member of the Monocacy Archaeological Society serving as president for two years. Hettie was awarded ASM's William B. Marye award in 1998. Barry Phelps noted, "Hettie Ballweber serves as an inspiration to follow the dual paths of scientific discovery in archeology, and personal dedication to principles and truth." She also served on the Board of Trustees of the Maryland Historical Trust.



Informally "retiring" in 2004, she and Bill founded Fast Friends Greyhound Rescue, Inc. where they worked to rescue greyhounds from the racetracks. In 11 years, they rescued over 700 greyhounds while quietly supporting work to end dog racing nationwide. When Bill was diagnosed with dementia, Hettie closed the rescue organization and took care of Bill until he went into the veteran's home in 2017. She filled her time by volunteering for a greyhound rescue group in Baltimore and becoming active again in the Monocacy Chapter of ASM.

When Bill died in early 2020, Hettie moved to Frederick where she served on the Frederick County Historic Preservation Commission and volunteered for the Frederick County Landmarks Foundation organizing their files, co-writing the Beatty Cramer House excavation report and headed an effort to place it on the National Register of Historic Places. At Frederick Community College she set up a permanent display of the artifacts from the Biggs Ford site in Frederick County. She also volunteered excavating and processing artifacts at two rhyolite quarry sites in Adams County, Pennsylvania, sharing her knowledge of prehistoric rhyolite use, technology and transport.

In 2023, she moved back to her hometown and became active in the Westmoreland Archaeological Society where connecting with old friends and colleagues. She and one of her colleagues recently published two papers on Monongahela complex sites in Pennsylvania Archaeologist. She has also organized the chapter's files and is in the process of creating a research library that contains books, papers, journals, etc. donated from Carnegie Museum, retired archaeologists, CRM firms, etc. So far, there are over 3,000 entries in the database. Hettie is grateful for the opportunities she was given to live her lifelong dream of becoming a professional archaeologist and it is reflected in the work she has accomplished during her career.

250 Years, Many Voices: *Digging into Maryland's Story*

Zac Singer, MD State Terrestrial Archeologist

Maryland Archeology Month 2026 will highlight the 250th Anniversary of the American Revolution. Topics discussed during Archeology Month will include Maryland's roles before, during, and after the Revolutionary War, archeological investigations of military campsites, what archeology reveals about everyday life in revolutionary Maryland, and how archaeology reframes "founding" stories.

Check out the ASM webpage for details about Archeology Month activities as they become available. If you have an event that you would like to have included in Maryland Archeology Month, use this link to submit information: MAM 2026 Event Submission Form.

2026 Tyler Bastian Field Session: Teague's Point

The ASM Field Session Committee held a virtual meeting on February 11th, 2026 to begin planning for the Field Session which will be held from 22 May to 1 June, 2026 at the Teague's Point site in Charles County. The meeting included representatives from the Maryland Historical Trust, the Charles County Parks department and others who will take part in the event.

Volunteers Needed!

The Maryland Historical Trust is hosting a Scouts BSA Archaeology Merit Badge Workshop this Spring and is looking for help!

On April 25, MHT is looking for **three (3) volunteers** to assist with running afternoon activity stations from 11:30 AM to 2:30 PM at the MHT Headquarters in Crownsville.

On May 1, MHT is looking for **two (2) volunteers** to assist on Friday to help set up equipment for the weekend at Fort Frederick State Park.

On May 2 & 3, MHT is looking for **five (5) volunteers with excavation experience** each day to assist with guiding the scouts during fieldwork at Fort Frederick State Park.

If you are interested in volunteering or would like more information, please contact Steph Soder at:

stephanie.soder@maryland.gov.

ASM Spring Symposium

People's Resource Center
100 Community Pl
Crownsville, MD 21032
Saturday, April 18th, 2026

See the attached Program for all the details! Can't wait to see you there.

In addition, we will hold the ASM Silent Auction to Benefit the Analysis Fund.

Volunteers and staff at the Montgomery County Parks Archeology lab.

You Can Help!

Silent Auction

We are soliciting items for auction at the Spring Symposium on April 18th at the People's Resource Center in Crownsville, MD. The auction will take place during the Symposium, and all proceeds will go to the ASM Analysis fund which allows us to help fund various analysis projects by paying for things such as radio-carbon dating, faunal/flora analysis, and others.

All donations are tax deductible. If you would like to make a donation or if you know of a business or person who would like to donate an item, please use the forms included with this newsletter to record details and send them to Cathy Camut, ASM Treasurer, who is running the event.

Donated items can be sent to Cathy or delivered to her before we get started on the Symposium on the 18th of April.

We appreciate your support in keeping our Analysis Fund working to support archeology projects throughout Maryland.

The MAC Lab Gets a New Look!

Patricia Samford, Director, Maryland Archaeological Conservation Lab

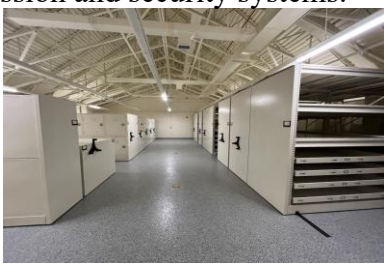
The Maryland Archaeological Conservation Lab at Jefferson Patterson Park and Museum is home to over 10 million archaeological artifacts spanning 12,000 years of human history in Maryland. These archaeological collections are available to students, scholars, museum curators, and educators for research, education, and exhibit purposes.

Shortly after the facility opened in 1998, Jefferson Patterson Park and Museum leadership began planning for a future expansion of the lab, knowing that the curation wing would eventually fill with collections. That foresight paid off; after years of planning and just as space for incoming collections ran out, in the spring of 2024 the lab became an active construction site. Working with designers Marshall Craft Associates, general contractors Coakley & Williams Construction (the firm who built the lab in the 1990s!), and the Department of General Services, park and lab staff have been pleased to see their vision of an expanded lab become a reality.

The newly constructed curation wing is visible (and highlighted) at the back of the photograph, extending at a 90-degree angle from the current curation wing.

The most visible change on the building's exterior is the addition of a two-story, 4985 square foot curation wing. The new wing sits at a 90-degree angle to the original curation wing and is joined to that space through a hyphen (Figure 1). The first floor of the new wing will house oversize objects on compactable shelving; the wing's second story contains more compactable storage: shelving and drawers for larger artifacts and scientific cabinets for study collections mounted on compactable rails (Figure 2). New compactable shelving units for boxed collections were added on both stories of the original curation wing, and it is estimated to have added enough space for an additional 40+ years of incoming archaeological collections.

Some of the other changes in the building include the addition of a new isolation room, a newly expanded field processing room, a dedicated room for storing field records on compactable shelving, a new 12-foot-long archaeological freeze-drier, and new fire suppression and security systems.



Scientific cabinets are installed on compactable rails (left) and shelving and drawers for oversize objects (right) on the second floor of the new curation wing.

As the construction project winds down in the late winter of 2026, lab staff is gearing up to get the lab in order (we swear everything in the lab has been moved at least three times!) and get the oversize collections back in the building and in their new storage locations. The reopening of the lab is anticipated to take place in the fall of 2026. Stay tuned for more information about the reopening!

Maryland Archeology Past Portraits

James "Jim" D. Sorensen

1944-2016

Dr. James D. Sorensen, Jim,' directed the Maryland-National Park & Planning Commission (M-NCPPC) Montgomery Parks' Archaeology Program for 23 years. Hired in 1988 by Mike Dwyer, M-NCPPC'S

ASM President Claude Bowen presents the 2011William B. Marye Award.

first historian, Jim became the first career archaeologist to work for the Commission. His 23 years with the Commission involved the surveying, identifying and registering of sites to keep up with the Park's and County's growing development. Projects ranged from Rockshelters and prehistoric quarries to French and Indian War taverns and Civil War encampments.

As Park Archaeologist, he not only supervised the many duties required of that position but was an inspiring force to his staff and the many volunteers with whom he shared his enthusiasm for the region's past. Dr. Sorensen left a legacy of preserving and interpreting numerous archeological sites with the county, with his crowning glory being Dowden's Ordinary Special Park in Clarksburg, Maryland.

Jim and his three sisters grew up on the Beall family farm in Hillandale, Maryland, where Jim got his first taste of archaeology as he hunted for 'arrowheads' in the woods and along the creek beds. His mother, Lucretia Ione Beall Sorensen, was an avid reader and would recount stories of the Indians who had first inhabited the area to her young son. Jim soaked up these stories and listened raptly to the stories of his family which were the stories of Montgomery County's first families.

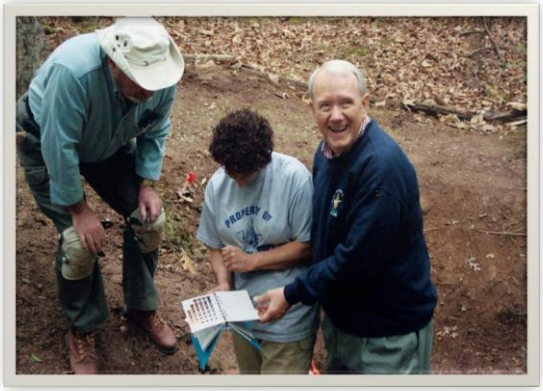
Educated in Latin and Greek, Jim taught Latin to students in Washington D.C. Public Schools before following his interests in languages at American University in the Department of Anthropology. While pursuing his Master of Arts degree in Linguistics, Jim was offered a chance to earn some money by the Potomac River Archaeology Survey Project (PRAS) directed by Dr. Charles McNett and Dr. June Evans. While working with PRAS Jim worked on many sites within Montgomery County and nearby Northern Virginia. His work under the direction of Dr. McNett and Dr. Evans at the Shawnee-Minisink Site in Eastern Pennsylvania prompted him to pursue his doctorate in Anthropology.

Working with the American University Consortium he studied and worked under many prominent archaeologists including Dr. William Gardner from Catholic University and Dr. Mark Leone from the University of Maryland. His work included directing an excavation at Reynolds Tavern for Archaeology in Annapolis and excavating at the Fairfield Plantation (Jackson Shrine) in Guinea Station, Virginia. Jim's archaeological work turned back home for the subject of his dissertation---the Riggs Plantation in Montgomery County, Maryland. Influenced by Henry Glassie's Folkhousing in Middle Virginia, Jim completed his dissertation Oaks II: Folk to National Culture in Nineteenth Century Montgomery County: Archaeological and Ethnohistorical Evidence from a Maryland Piedmont Plantation in 1987. Soon after, he was hired to become M-NCPPC's first archaeologist for Montgomery Parks.

During his tenure as Montgomery Parks archaeologist, Jim partnered with Montgomery College professors Dr. Eugenia Robinson and Dr. Mary Gallagher in educating anthropology students in archaeology. The partnership produced several archaeological reports and 'An Archaeological Resource Management Plan for Montgomery County: Understanding and Stewarding Our Cultural Heritage' in 2002, co-authored by Jim and Professors Robinson and Gallagher in 1999.

Jim was always generous with his knowledge and partnered with the Volunteers in Archaeology program for high school students sponsored by Robert Hines, the former History Department Chairman at Richard Montgomery High School. He was devoted to service and volunteered for the Montgomery County Historical Society Library and was a founding member of the Montgomery County Civil War Roundtable. He retained membership in the Archeological Society of Maryland, Inc. (ASM, Inc.) and served on the Board of Trustees for many years. In addition, he was a vital member of ASM's Mid-Potomac Chapter (formerly Southwestern Chapter) as well, offering chapter members opportunities to excavate and work in the archaeology labs for Montgomery Parks. In 2011, Jim was awarded the William B. Marye Award for his contributions to Maryland Archaeology.

The archaeology program that Jim initiated continues. The partnerships, volunteer opportunities, and enthusiasm for lifelong learning are a legacy of Jim Sorensen's lifetime commitment to the rich cultural history of Montgomery County, Maryland.



Jim Sorenson working on site.

Past Portraits is an ongoing project to document the stories of people who have contributed to archeology in Maryland. This series was first published in the Eastern States Archaeological Federation Journal, *Archaeology of Eastern North America*, in 2020 and highlights personalities that have contributed to archeology in Maryland over time. ASMInk will publish excerpts from this series.

ASM Chapter News

Central Chapter:

Central Chapter meetings are by Zoom only. Katharine Fernstrom sends the link to the email group. Stay tuned for more details. For more information and to be added to the Zoom list contact Katharine Fernstrom at katharine.fernstrom@marylandarcheology.org

Charles County:

Meets in person September through April at the Community Room of the LaPlata Police Department in LaPlata, MD on the third Thursday of the month. Email ccasm2010@gmail.com for more information.

Eastern Shore:

Dates and events are on chapter's website (ASM Eastern Shore), Facebook page (Eastern Shore Maryland Archaeology) and Instagram (@esmdarch). For more information, email esarcheology@gmail.com or jamrkin2@washcooll.edu

Calendar is here: bit.ly/ASM-ES and events are open to members and nonmembers. To be added to our social media updates, email esarcheology@gmail.com.
All events are open to anyone who wants to attend!

Open lab at Washington College: Contact Julie Markin at jmarkin2@washcoll.edu.

Mid-Potomac:

The chapter meets the third Thursday of the month from September through June. In-person meetings begin at 7p.m. for the business meeting followed by a presentation at around 7:30. The chapter meets at the ADU Showroom, 8501 Grovemont Circle, Gaithersburg, MD 20877. Please contact Don Housley for directions, if necessary.

Pizza will be available before the in-person meeting starting at 6:30pm for $6 per

person. If virtual meetings are necessary, they will be via Zoom with the business meeting also starting at 7 p.m. and the presentation around 7:30. Contact Don Housley to RSVP for pizza by 12 noon on the day of the meeting and for virtual Zoom meeting codes.

For up-to-date information concerning meetings, please contact Don Housley, 301-424-8526, check the Mid-Potomac Chapter Website or send an email to: asmmidpotomac@gmail.com.

Upcoming Events At Mid-Potomac:

Thursday, April 16, 2026: Wendy Harris, chapter member and professional archaeologist will talk on investigating the business of ice-harvesting in the Hudson Valley of New York and how it contrasts with ice-harvesting by some local Maryland landowners.

Thursday, March 19 via Zoom: Beth Bollwerk, chapter member and Project Manager for the Digital Archaeological Archive of Comparative Slavery at Monticello will give an update of her Colonware research grant.

Thursday, May 21, 2026: Local historian and chapter member Ralph Buglass will speak on "Out of the Way places in Montgomery County."

June: Chapter picnic. Date and location to be determined.

Monocacy:

For information contact: monocacyarcheology@gmail.com (mailbox monitored intermittently) or call Jeremy Lazelle at 301-471-8433.

Northern Chesapeake:

A business meeting at 7pm and is followed by the presentation at 7:30. Locations vary. Contact Dan Coates at 410-808-2398 or dancoates@comcast.net

Western Maryland:

Programs are held the fourth Friday of the month, at 7:30 pm at the **History Discovery Center at Blue Spring at 400 N. Mechanic Street, Cumberland, MD.** Unless noted. Chapter email: wmdasm@yahoo.com

Meeting announcements are sent also to CTN; WFWM, and the Oakland Republican.

Contact Us

The **Archeological Society of Maryland Inc.** is a statewide nonprofit organization devoted to the study and conservation of Maryland archeology.

ASM members receive the monthly newsletter, ASM Ink, publication notice of the biannual journal, MARYLAND ARCHEOLOGY, reduced admission to ASM events and a 10-percent discount on items sold by the Society.

Contact Membership Secretary Ethan Bean, ethan.bean@marylandarcheology.org, for membership rates.

ASM Officers

President
Valerie Hall
valerie.hall@marylandarcheology.org
301-814-8028

Vice-President
Katharine Fernstrom
katharine.fernstrom@marylandarcheology.org

Secretary
Patricia Melville
pvmelville@verizon.net

Membership Secretary
Ethan Bean
ethan.bean@marylandarcheology.org

Treasurer
Cathy Camut
cathy.camut@marylandarcheology.org

At-Large Trustees

- Lynne Bulhack
- Brent Chippendale
- Danielle Knight
- Don Housley
- Jim Gibb
- Julia Berg

ASMInk Editors:

Valerie Hall -
valerie.hall@marylandarcheology.org

John Fiveash -
jsfiveash@marylandarcheology.org

Caitlyn Jennings -
caitlyn.jennings@marylandarcheology.org